



Love for the game: "If we wanted to make money, we wouldn't have been doubles players. We chose doubles because we genuinely liked playing doubles a lot more than singles," admits Chirag. GETTY IMAGES

marriage. There must be adjustments, and you need to back each other up when things are not working well for you.

You had a string of wins in tournament finals dating to 2019. Don't you get nervous, or do you just go to a different level? Was there a particular win in the final that changed things for you?

Chirag: We are always a little pumped up when we play in finals. Playing in big matches is what you aim for as a player. It would be a lie if someone said there is no pressure; it's up to you how you convert it into motivation. That pressure spurs you to do even better than in the previous couple of matches. Like Satwik said, the Thomas Cup final, where we won after being 17-20, was very crucial. To

win it in that fashion, I think, gave us the confidence that we can play and win big finals. Not just win but win from any situation.

Do you follow the Indian doubles badminton scene? Do you talk to youngsters?

Satwik: We try to follow who is playing well. If he's making some wrong choices, we will try to correct him. Or if there are problems with partnerships. Sometimes, if someone is not playing well, their partner would want to change immediately and split up. So, we try to tell them to be patient and communicate with each other.

Do you take inspiration from other athletes?

Chirag: Rafael Nadal and Usain

Bolt have always been my sporting heroes. I try to imbibe all of their good qualities as much as possible. They have that never-say-die attitude and intensity where they give 100 per cent on the court, but when they are off it, they'll be as chill as possible.

Satwik: I'm the complete opposite of him. I like Roger Federer and his calmness. And Dhoni, too, for the same reason — he is very calm in pressure situations. I also admire how passionate Virat Kohli is about his cricket. There is no rest day for him. He's very hungry every day, like he wants more, more, more, more and more. I wonder whether, as a human, he gets tired at least once. He plays with the same fire whether he's playing for a club, a small match or a major competition. He's consistent with his fitness as well. That's the quality of a top athlete.

Do you guys play any other sports to relax?

Satwik: I used to play before, but nowadays I try to avoid it. Once I got a very silly injury in my hand while playing beach volleyball. I was so embarrassed that I pretended I fell off a bike. I just don't want to let that happen again. I want to take care of my body. I also like to play basketball but not the high-impact kind. I prefer just throwing the ball into the basket, like Stephen Curry.

Chirag: Something similar happened to me in 2017. I was playing football with my friends when I tripped over the ball. I had a bad ankle sprain and since then I have not gone back to the football field. Also, we don't have the time to play any other sport right now. If we train for six days, we will be dead tired by Sunday. We just want to chill and not play any other sport and get our body even more tired.

Apart from the Olympics, what are your hopes from 2024

Chirag: To be happy, enjoy the process and be patient. When we do that, I think we play even better. Looking back at 2023, winning and standing on the podium did make us happy but the process leading up to it was even more special.